couldn’t help thinking to myself, ‘They should let me bat in peace,’ and it wasn’t long before I was out.

When you are batting well, it’s good to have the crowd behind you like that. When you are struggling, it can make things doubly difficult. After the Hyderabad Test I said to Gary and Paddy that I was looking forward to the South Africa series because at least the crowds there wouldn’t obsess about it so much.

I actually had a good chance to get the century out of the way in Nagpur in the third Test, which started on 20 November. I was 57 not out overnight in our only innings and went in on the third day feeling pretty confident. It didn’t work out, however, as I lost my wicket after adding only four runs to my score, getting an edge off the left-arm seamer Andy McKay to the wicketkeeper. It was a ball that kicked up from short of a good length – the only one to do so all morning.

India in South Africa, December 2010–January 2011

Playing South Africa in South Africa was always a difficult proposition. The nature of the pitches, an excellent fast-bowling attack and a good batting unit combined to make them a formidable opponent at home.

In a poor start to the series, we were bowled out for 136 in our first innings at Centurion Park on 16 December, with Morne Morkel taking five wickets, and it was almost impossible to stage a comeback from that position. I was the top scorer with 36 and I wasn’t playing too badly when a Dale Steyn delivery came in more than expected to trap me in front. South Africa put together a huge total in response, with a double century for Jacques Kallis and hundreds for Amla and de Villiers, and we were left to bat for almost two and a half days to save the game.

We at least put up more of a fight in the second innings. Dhoni and I were involved in a very good counter-attacking partnership of 172 and I was relieved to make my fiftieth Test hundred at last. We could see the South Africans getting frustrated and towards the end of the fourth day Dale Steyn and I exchanged a few words. The fading light had prompted Graeme Smith to give Steyn a final burst and he came charging in. At one point he joked to me that he wasn’t bowling too fast, for it was a touch above 150 kph. At this I asked him, ‘Where was your bravado when the sun was out?’ To be honest, all this banter did was strengthen